the 1980s. He then became a member of Harkat-ul Mujahideen in Khost province of Afghanistan. He soon became a reckoning person in the ranks of the groups mainly because of his hardline approach and fierce speeches. It is believed that during his association with HuM, he came into contact with the Al Qaeda leadership, including its chief Osama bin Laden.

The chiefs of three different schools of thought who supported the creation of JeM were Mufti Nizamuddin Shamizai of Majlis-e-Tawana-e-Islami, Moulana Mufti Rasheem Ahmad of Darulifta-Wal-Irshad and Maulana Sher Ali of Sheikh ul Hadith Dar ul Haqqania.

In a short period, JeM developed good relationships with other militant organisations operating in Kashmir and Afghanistan, including Al Qaeda, Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) and Lashkar-e-Jhangvi (LeJ). Before the US invasion of Afghanistan in 2001 and subsequent closure of its training camps in Afghanistan, it used to train its activists in camps inside Afghanistan under the patronage of Afghan Taliban (Hussain, 2007). During this period, these activists came into direct contact with Al Qaeda, resulting in some sort of relationship, although the nature of these relationships was not known. There was a well-established and publically known relationship between the JeM and the Taliban. In addition, the official newspaper of JeM called *Zarb-e-Momin* was at the forefront of propaganda for Taliban in Afghanistan.

Zarb-e-Momin was initially published by the Al-Rashid Trust, a social welfare organisation that works as a front for militant propaganda and then as a source of funding for the group. The funding from the trust was the chief source of funding for the militant group that helped it expand its activities even beyond the border into Afghanistan. The ban on the group did not affect the publishing of the newspaper.

Furthermore, JeM had a strong relationship with another proscribed sectarian organisation called Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (SSP). This close relationship was mainly due to the close links between the heads of two groups, for instance, Maulana Masood Azhar and Maulana Azam Tariq from JeM and SSP, respectively (Rana, 2009). The intimate relationship was evident from a demonstration by JeM, in which Maulana Azam Tariq not only participated but also provided fighters to JeM in its holy war against India on 5 February 2000. Both the organisations had almost the same recruitment base; for instance, madrasahs spread across Pakistan, particularly in the Punjab province of